

The structure for the college needs to be better defined. How are decisions made? Who makes which decisions?

Structural Perspective

As Ohlone College is embarking on a new vision as Learning College, it is prudent for the leader of the college to clearly communicate to all constituencies what the goal is and lay out a roadmap to get there from here. A well-thought-out organizational structure is essential to achieving a successful outcome, and vertical coordination is also necessary to spread the communication throughout the whole organization. Such communication coordinates individual and group efforts and links local initiatives with organization goals. In addition, it has higher level visibility and coordinates the work of subordinates through authority, rules and policies, and planning and control systems. Lastly, this structure provides a clear definition of the roles, relationships, and communication between all people involved.

Though a Professional Organization, Ohlone College currently functions very much as a Machine Bureaucracy organization, with each function in its appropriate box—instruction and student services, personnel, finance, human resources, community relations, information systems, institutional research, and so on. It has the same specialized subcultures, disciplines and divisions between the faculty and the administrator. Its vertical organizational structure also lacks clarity regarding how are decisions are made and by whom, and how roles and units are coordinated.

Change to a learning college model contributes to the transformation of the culture of higher education. Essentially it is a blueprint for formal expectations and learning outcomes. However, the definition of the learning college is somewhat

ambiguous and thus has different meanings for each person depending on one's in the organization.

As stated by O'Banion, the Learning College:

- Creates substantive change in the individual learner.
- Engages learners as full partners in the learning process, with learners assuming primary responsibility for their choices.
- Creates and offers as many options for learning as possible.
- Assists learners to form and participate in collaborative learning activities.
- Defines the roles of learning facilitators by the needs of the learners.
- Measures success by documented improved and expanded learning for its learners.

There is a clear need for a formal structure on how to accommodate both collective goals and individual differences. The learning college model can only occur when goals, roles, and responsibilities are all clearly defined.

Based on Mintzberg's Taxonomy of Organizational Forms, Ohlone College is a Professional Organization but it functions as a Machine Bureaucracy (Bolman, Lee, and Deal, 75-77). It has highly specialized, routine operating tasks, formalized procedures as its operating core, a proliferation of rules and regulations, formalized communication throughout the organization, relatively centralized power for decision making, and an elaborate administrative structure with sharp distinctions between line and staff. This type of top-down structure is typical of a community college configuration with management presiding over "silos" within the organization. In order to revise an existing organization structure, it's practical to determine what is working, what is not working (and why), and restructure accordingly. It is important to remember that structure is necessary only to provide support for the organization. Restructuring should be implemented if necessary because of environment shifts, technological changes,

organizational growth, leadership changes, or the organization is troubled. Having a well-defined structure is not only important, but it also provides a means of communication and collaboration for the whole organization. One solution might be to assign a department chairperson or representative who can be responsible for communicating to their department.

Recommendations

- Build a critical coalition.
- Create an emerging vision.
- Involve all stakeholders in the long process.
- Acknowledge that:
 1. Change is not a goal in and of itself.
 2. Change requires patience, resources and the support of the president and trustees.
 3. Change to a learning college model requires that all stakeholders become learners in and through the process of change.
 4. Campus-wide representation in the process of (1) identifying institutional goals and objectives, and (2) developing a vision statement that reflects the institution's mission and commitment to a learning college model is vital.
- Connect Learning college initiatives to strategic planning.
- An assessment of the human and financial resource commitments is required and critical to change to a learning college and to sustain the paradigm shift.
- The role of technology in the creation of a learning-focused environment needs to be assessed.
- Faculty leadership of the process must be reiterated.
- Student and staff need to be involved from the outset.
- Successful outcomes require: collaboration, access to information, cross-functional teams, institutional support and time to process new ideas and create trust.
- External consultants and facilitators enhance the process.
- Readings and discussions on current issues in education, organizational change and environments cans can help contextualize institutional change.

References

Greater Expectations National Panel by Terry O'Banion - A LEARNING COLLEGE FOR THE 21ST CENTURY, American Council on Education, Series on Higher Education, Phoenix AZ: Oryx Press, 1997

Bolman, Lee, and Deal, Terrence. Reframing Organizations: Artistry, Choice and Leadership. 3rd. Jossey-Bass. 2003